



Making Sense of Emotional Intelligence

Phase 1, Week 7: Please *complete* this workbook before this week's group call

A Quick Review:

- I. *How are the 10 Pillars of Transformational Parenting showing up in your daily parenting?*

- II. *Are you noticing when you find yourself in inner security? How do you parent when you feel self-connected, even if temporary?*

- III. *Are you practicing your calming sensory tool? What works for you to find your calm? What is your child's sensory calming tool?*

- IV. *Are you practicing forgiveness of yourself? Are you apologizing to your child when you make a mistake?*

- V. *Are you noticing when your mindset is stuck in limiting beliefs? What has it been like for you to imagine a new way of seeing yourself? (Example: Instead of parenting from “no one hears me,” choose to parent from “I am secure in my voice.”)*

Emotional Intelligence

What is Emotional Intelligence?

According to psychologists Peter Salovey (Yale) and John Mayer (University of New Hampshire), emotional intelligence is:

- The ability to monitor one's own, and others' feelings and emotions.
- The capability of discriminating our feelings to use as information to guide one's thinking and actions.

To understand how to name our emotions and our feelings accurately, we support our body and our mind to push the pause button before reaction. We are learning the sequence of self-regulation so we can model and support our children to learn to do the same, in time.

Why Does Emotional Intelligence Matter In Parenting?

Why do we need to know how to feel our feelings? Why do we need to understand how to communicate complex feelings and needs? According to Lindsay C. Gibson, a psychologist and author of *Adult Children of Emotionally Immature Parents*, emotionally mature people are:

- Willing to work with reality rather than fighting it. Can accept "what is" not what "should be."
- Able to feel and think at the same time; capable of feeling stressed & exhausted, AND can remain capable of conscious thought and action.
- Have agency with their emotional releases & can choose when to release & when to contain.
- Able to avoid taking everything personally; see other people's feelings and experiences as theirs and can differentiate their feelings from others.
- Respectful of other people's boundaries and can set their own.
- Flexible and compromise well.
- Willing to be influenced (not rigid and unwilling to grow and transform in a way that serves).
- Able to apologize and make amends and willing to reflect on their actions and try to change harmful behavior.
- Capable of being present and actively listening.
- Willing to ask for help when they need it. Can practice humility and vulnerability.



Those sound great, don't they? We all want these for our children when they are grown. How does developing Emotional Intelligence help us (and our children) evolve to this point? Emotional Intelligence is the language we must learn in order to thrive in intimate, interpersonal relationships. Understanding our emotions, and the communication between our heart, head, and nervous system supports us, as the parents, to embody the emotionally mature qualities we long for our children to adopt as they grow. Communicating our feelings, needs, and beliefs supports us to be heard, to be understood, and to see beneath the behavior of our children, and ourselves.

Communicating Feelings, Needs, and Beliefs

Empowered Parents embrace expansive beliefs that:

- Every behavior of our children is their best attempt to get their needs met.
- As adults, it is our job to help our child learn how to effectively communicate their feelings and needs so they do not have to resort to challenging behavior. This takes *time*, patience, and brain development!
- No child is naughty or bad. The child's behavior is entirely separate from the child and does not reflect their innate value or worthiness.

Meeting our children with empathy and curiosity versus punishment and shame will:

- Grow our children's brains and nervous systems so they are more capable of experiencing a strong emotion without reacting from it (all "bad" behavior is our child's inability to cope with a strong and uncomfortable feeling).
- Give our children the tools they need to communicate.
- Expand our child's inner security and decrease cortisol levels, allowing their natural essence to shine through, instead of living from defense, chronic stress, and chronic reactivity.

To understand how we are feeling and interact with these feelings with emotional objectivity and healthy detachment, we can intelligently translate these feelings as:

- Communication of unmet needs.
- Communication of a conversation that needs to take place.
- Indication of a crossed boundary.
- Communication of taking something personally and reacting to another's behavior, and an invitation to turn inward and pause before responding.



Empathy is an Empowered Parent's Superpower!

"Fear says: fix it. Love says: create the environment and maintain the relationship to allow it to fix itself." - Bryan Post

Empathy is the ability to attune to your inner world and name your feelings and needs. Naming your feelings and needs strengthens the emotional processing centers in your brain.

Practicing emotional intelligence builds neural networks between the middle brain and front brain. This means that with lots of practice, you will be able to accurately name your emotional state and sophisticated feelings, and with every rep, you will strengthen your prefrontal cortex. You will strengthen the foundation of emotionally mature behaviors from the inside out. We cannot "will" ourselves into emotional maturity. We must FEEL ourselves into emotional maturity.

When we meet our children with empathy, we are strengthening the emotional regulators in their brains. If we want our children to be emotionally mature, we must meet them with affirmation, validation, and understanding of their inner world.

Learn how to validate the feelings, needs, thoughts, and beliefs beneath the behavior (remember Root to Bloom Process).

Example: A child hits their sister while playing in the sandbox.

Instead of reacting with:	Try this:
<i>"Hey! Stop hitting, we don't hit," or "I get to be angry but you do not get to hit!"</i>	<i>"Oh honey, I see your anger, I'm here to support you." or "Hey, come here. I'm here. I've got you...." Then AFTER the child is calm, we ask them questions, NOT lecture: "I noticed you back there and how your body hit. Tell me your story..what happened? Mama/daddy is here to help you feel angry, and keep yourself and others safe. I love you."</i>

Affirm the feelings beneath the behavior.

Example: I heard that you were talking back to your teacher today.

Instead of reacting with:	Try this:
<i>"How many times do I need to tell you that you can't talk like that!" or "You can feel frustrated honey, but you cannot talk to your teacher that way."</i>	<i>"I am feeling worried about how you're feeling at school. I wonder if you're feeling lonely and longing for respect and understanding with your teacher? I'd love to hear what's going on for you. I know how capable you are of communicating." or "Help me understand what happened at school, tell me your story? Oh...I see..sounds like you were longing to be heard, huh? Of course, that makes sense. I wonder...how can we solve this problem next time, without harsh words?"</i>

VI. What do you notice in the red box? How does this differ from the green?

VII. Put yourself into the mind of a child. How would they FEEL hearing the red box vs. the green?

Reflect back.

Example: Child does not want to go to sleep and is struggling to calm down.

Instead of reacting with:	Try this:
<i>"Stop complaining, we do this every day. You got to stay up late, you should be grateful!"</i> or <i>"I know you don't want to sleep, but you have to, or you'll be tired tomorrow."</i>	<i>"Yes, I hear you. You wish you could stay up later. I wish that too. Maybe one day, you and I will stay up all night and sleep all day! And, it's bedtime. Should we hop to bed like bunnies, or slither like snakes?!"</i> or <i>"Hey, I'm here to help. Seems like you're feeling restless and your body needs to get the wiggles out. Let's cycle our legs in the air for five minutes, then I'll scratch your back to sleep."</i>

VIII. *What do you notice in the red box? How does this differ from the green?*

IX. *Put yourself into the mind of a child. How would they FEEL hearing the red box vs. the green?*

Connect a feeling to a need.

Example: Child is whining and complaining about how bored they are.

Instead of reacting with:	Try this:
<i>"Only boring kids get bored!"</i> or <i>"We do not whine in our house. If you're bored, go figure out something to do. You can solve your own problems."</i>	<i>"Feeling bored huh? Yeah, I know that feeling, love. Hm... wanna keep sitting here feeling bored, or do you wanna get out your new puzzle and get started?"</i>

X. What do you notice in the red box? How does this differ from the green?

XI. Put yourself into the mind of a child. How would they FEEL hearing the red box vs. the green?

How empathy strengthens our children:

- Soothes the fear response in the brain, and floods the child's system with relaxation, allowing them to soften into connection, cooperation, and collaboration.
- Regulates their brain and nervous system. "Name it to frame it."
- Feeling and body connection, allowing our children to feel more safe in their bodies.
- Supports child's self-awareness and self-empathy, encourages expansive beliefs.

What Keeps Us From Empathy?

We have been conditioned NOT to feel, and to suppress emotions. We have been taught to fear our emotions, and to associate emotions with punishment, disconnection, humiliation, and shame.

- XII. *With the following 6 primal emotions, write down the word(s) that immediately come to your mind. (Example: Anger is dangerous, bad, wrong. Or, happiness is good, safe, wanted.)*

- | | |
|-------------------|----------------------|
| 1. Anger is _____ | 4. Joy is _____ |
| 2. Grief is _____ | 5. Shame is _____ |
| 3. Fear is _____ | 6. Surprise is _____ |

- XIII. *What beliefs have you learned from your upbringing and conditioning about emotions?*

Expressing emotions is: _____
(good, bad, healthy, unhealthy, simple, complicated)

These emotions are good: _____

These emotions are bad: _____

- XIV. *As a child, if I cried when I was disappointed or sad, I would have been met with:*

- XV. *If I was scared and needed consoling as a child, my caregiver would have responded by:*

XVI. *When I was joyful as a child, I was treated with:*

XVII. *When I was feeling ashamed by something as a child, my caregiver would respond by:*

XVIII. *Answer the following:*

Feeling sadness is comfortable for me.	YES	NO
Feeling anger is common for me.	YES	NO
I saw my caregivers express their emotions in healthy ways.	YES	NO
I was taught to stuff my emotions and be “strong.”	YES	NO
I was met with empathy and warmth when I was in emotional pain as a child.	YES	NO
I know how to contain my emotions in a healthy way, and think before I act, even when mad, sad, or tired.	YES	NO



XIX. What limiting beliefs have you internalized about your child's emotions and emotional expression?

Do you accept or reject:	Accept	Reject
<i>"If you give in to a child's tantrums and act soft, you will teach them they can get whatever they want by pitching a fit."</i>		
<i>"There are good feelings and there are bad feelings."</i>		
<i>"Spoiled children are created by a parent validating their child's emotions."</i>		
<i>"Letting children feel their feelings is coddling them and not teaching them how to exist in the real world."</i>		
<i>"If you respond with empathy and validation to a child's feelings and let them stay in their feelings until they pass, you teach your child to sulk in their sorrow and think depression is normal."</i>		
<i>"Emotions are fine to feel, but there are acceptable ways of feeling them, and unacceptable ways of feeling them."</i>		
<i>"My child should be able to control their feelings on their own."</i>		
<i>"My child being allowed to feel their feelings is unproductive and inconvenient for me."</i>		
<i>"A child who throws a tantrum is a brat, and should be punished for their behavior."</i>		

Remembering How to Feel

Most of us were not met with curiosity and empathy when we tried (and inevitably failed) to communicate our feelings and needs as children. Instead, we were met with punishment, invalidation, or dismissal. Others of us were met by caregivers who genuinely wanted to help us, but lacked the adequate emotional tools to do so.

We were not shown how to feel, or how to express our feelings. According to Marc Brackett, author of *Permission to Feel*, intellectualizing our feelings is not the same as FEELING them, meaning we must feel in our physical bodies, and allow ourselves physical self-empathy, before putting a name to the feeling and need.

Nonverbal self-empathy: paying attention to where in the body we are feeling a strong emotional sensation. Putting a hand on that space, and giving it our full awareness. Reminding ourselves that this feeling is temporary, and the more we allow it to flow through us, the more quickly it will pass.

- **F:** Focus on the physical sensation of the feeling.
- **E:** Embrace this moment as a “temporary teacher,” here to communicate.
- **E:** Expand into the left brain: invite 3 feeling words.
- **L:** Label the underlying need(s).

Emotion And Body Connection

NOTE: if this exercise seems difficult for you, pay attention throughout your week to how you're feeling. While you're driving, or cooking dinner, ask yourself, how do I feel right now? Where do I feel that in my body?

XX. *Where do you feel **anger** in your body?*

XXI. *Where do you feel **grief** in your body?*



XXII. *Where do you feel **overwhelm** in your body?*



XXIII. *Where do you feel **joy** in your body?*



XXIV. *Where do you feel **compassion** in your body?*



XXV. *Where do you feel **excitement** in your body?*

XXVI. *Where do you feel **anxiety** in your body?*

XXVII. *Where do you feel **curiosity** in your body?*

Breaking Through Old Stories by Learning the Language of the Heart

We are in an overly exciting time in humanity. Science is showing us how intricately connected our nervous system, brain, and emotions are in creating a healthy, vibrant, secure attachment within ourselves and our children.

We are learning how modeling these skills to our children and being WITH them as they learn these skills, gives us everything we need to raise children who are secure, confident, resilient, compassionate, and visionary. Most of us were not prepared with a language of feelings and needs.

Knowing, feeling, and embodying the abilities to name, affirm, and differentiate between the emotional/heart intelligences is a core pillar in our ability to express, receive, and experience love and belonging. We can genuinely give our children empathy when we are rooted in self-empathy.

Self-Empathy:

The willingness to accept, without judgment, how you feel. The willingness to allow yourself to feel those feelings in your body without running away, pushing against, or stuffing down. The willingness to name the feelings and the needs, in order for you to contain the feelings and allow them to pass, and to take initiative on getting your needs met.

Verbal Self-Empathy:

I feel _____ because I am needing, I am longing for, or I deeply value _____.

Example 1: A parent yells at their child to get in the car.

This parent is not able to communicate (whether internally or externally):

- To self: *"I feel hopeless because I am longing for ease."*
- To child: *"Are you willing to work as a team with me? I believe that you and I are capable of this. Shall we touch elbows all the way to the car?"*



Example 2: A parent grabs his son's arm after the son "back talks" him in front of other parents at the park, and tells the child "we are leaving right now."

This parent is not able to communicate:

- To self: *"Oh...I feel hurt hearing those words. Consideration and kindness are my core values."*
- To child: *"Ouch, you must be feeling pretty stressed bud. Here, come on my lap. I love you and I want to help you feel safe."* (Later...the parent can utilize SOOTHE as mentioned later in this workbook.)

Example 3: A parent grabs the video game console and rips it out of the TV because their child did not turn it off when the parent asked.

This parent was struggling to understand and accept that:

- To self: *"I'm feeling so stressed right now. I'm confused. I don't know why I feel so intensely. But I accept that this is how I feel. I am needing some support right now. I will ask someone I trust to help my son so I don't do anything I regret" OR "I'm going to take a small break outside and come back and try again when I'm calm."*
- To child: *"Hey bud, I see you're having a hard time with this transition. I'm needing a small break outside, then we can try again."* (Later...the parent can utilize SOOTHE as mentioned later in this workbook.)

Self-Empathy Pauses Our Patterned Reactivity

Can you recall a time this week when you reacted instead of responded? In self-reflection, can you give yourself empathy? Refer to the feelings and needs list in the next section.

XXVIII. *This was the scenario:*

XXIX. *This is how I felt witnessing the scenario:*

XXX. *These are the unmet needs I was having in that moment:*

XXXI. *These were the judgments I was having:*

XXXII. *These were the fears I was attached to:*

XXXIII. *These were the beliefs that I didn't realize I was believing:*



Feelings Resulting from Unfulfilled Needs or Limiting Beliefs

Angry / Embarrassed	Vulnerable / Fatigued	Sad / Confused
Livid Ashamed Irate Flustered Resentful Mortified Enraged Self Conscious Furious	Insecure Burned out Reserved Depleted Wary Exhausted Unsure Lethargic Fragile Listless Guarded Shaky Worn Out	Disappointed Ambivalent Depressed Baffled Dejected Bewildered Disheartened Conflicted Discouraged Lost
Pain	Tense	Afraid
Agony Anguish Devastated Grieving Heartbroken Hurt Regretful	Anxious Cranky Frazzled Irritable Nervous Overwhelmed Stressed	Apprehensive Dread Mistrustful Panicked Scared
Annoyed	Distressed	Disconnected
Aggravated Bothered Displeased Exasperated Frustrated	Distraught Restless Troubled Agitated Unsettled	Apathetic Bored Detached Distant Indifferent

Feelings Resulting from Fulfilled Needs or Expansive Beliefs

Peaceful / Inspired	Engaged / Confident	Affectionate / Hopeful
Blissful Amazed Astonished Centered Awed Clear Rapturous Ecstatic Serene Uplifted Tranquil Wonder	Absorbed Empowered Curious Proud Engrossed Safe Enchanted Self-Assured Involved	Closeness Expectant Compassionate Encouraged Friendly Optimistic Tender Open Loving Trusting
Curious	Joyful	Excited
Adventurous Alert Interested Intrigued Mellow Surprised Spellbound Stimulated	Amused Buoyant Delighted Elated Fascinated Jubilant Radiant	Alive Amazed Eager Enthusiastic Invigorated Lively Passionate
Grateful	Relaxed	Refreshed
Appreciative Moved Thankful Touched	At ease Carefree Comfortable Content	Enlivened Rejuvenated Rested Restored Energetic

7 Basic Human Needs of a Child

(Adapted from Dr. William Glasser's Choice Theory and the Five Basic Needs.)

- | | |
|--|--------------------------------------|
| 1. Survival / Safety / Security | 5. Power / Empowerment |
| 2. Unconditional Love / Belonging / Authenticity | 6. Freedom / Autonomy / Independence |
| 3. Attention / Affection / Appreciation | 7. Fun / Play / Discovery |
| 4. Emotional Attunement / Empathy | |

***Reminder:** Every behavior a child exhibits is the child's best attempt at fulfilling a need.

XXXIV. *How are the following 7 Basic Human Needs of your child being met daily? When that need is being met, how does your child feel? How do they behave?*

*The need for **Survival / Safety / Security**:*

--

*The need for **Unconditional Love / Belonging / Authenticity**:*

--

*The need for **Attention / Affection / Appreciation**:*

--

The need for **Emotional Attunement / Empathy:**

The need for **Power / Empowerment:**

The need for **Freedom / Autonomy / Independence:**

The need for **Fun / Play / Discovery:**



Emotional Intelligence Strengthens Expansive Beliefs

Every time we respond with empathy and genuine curiosity to understand our child's feelings and needs beneath a behavior, we strengthen their connection to expansive beliefs. A child's needs are vast and often layered, just like ours. As your child's needs are met, then your child may experience feelings such as happiness, delight, amusement, security, and comfort. However, when these needs are not met, your child may experience feelings of sadness, confusion, fear, frustration, and anger.

There is another level to this explanation of basic human needs getting met or not met. Sometimes, your child will have the feeling of anger and if we take a look underneath that feeling of anger, we see that your child has a need for connection. Seems simple, huh? Just provide your child with some connection and his feeling of anger shifts, right?

Yes, just the simple act of connecting with your child may shift your child's anger. However, when you assist your child in getting a basic need met, such as connection, your child's anger may remain. If your child's anger remains even after your child has had this basic human need met, then your child may have a core limiting belief around connection that is not allowing the connection to take effect, and to be FELT.

We are interested here in identifying two states for your child:

- What your child is needing so you can better understand their feelings.
- What your child is believing about their needs so your child can establish positive belief patterns about their needs.

Your Child's Needs and Belief Patterns, From Their Perspective:

Unconditional Love & Acceptance (Authenticity): "Treat me with dignity and respect. Treat me with the same respect you would treat any adult. Hold space for my feelings. Understand my brain development. Do not punish me for being a child".

Example of a core belief pattern around acceptance:

- Limiting: "Nobody cares about who I really am."
- Expansive: "I love and accept myself."



Accomplishment: "I am a curious adventurer and explorer of the world around me. Everything is new and looks like an awesome challenge. Don't micromanage my every move. Let me explore! Create YES spaces for me. When it is a NO, say this with warmth. When I have big feelings about your no, accept these and offer me empathy."

Example of a core belief pattern around accomplishment:

- Limiting: "I can't do it!"
- Expansive: "I can learn to do anything."

Affection: "I love being close to you and feeling your affection towards me. Look into my eyes and take deep breaths. Choose to be near me when you can. Your affection soothes my nervous system and provides me with a deep sense of comfort and home."

Example of a core belief pattern around affection:

- Limiting: "Nobody wants to touch me or be near me."
- Expansive: "I am lovable," "I am wanted," and "I belong here."

Appreciation and Belonging: "I need to feel like I am welcome and that I belong here. I feel fulfilled when I am appreciated for who I am and not only for something that I accomplish. I am seen for who I am. You see me beneath my behaviors. You get curious, not mad, when I make a mistake. You help me reflect so I feel at home in my mind and body."

Example of a core belief pattern around appreciation:

- Limiting: "I have to do what you say so you love me. Nobody gets me. I don't belong anywhere."
- Expansive: "I am appreciated for just being me. I don't have to prove that I am worthy of being a part of a team."

Autonomy: "I need to feel the space to explore and grow on my own. I love knowing that I am a valuable contribution to our family. When my boundary is "I DO IT MYSELF", let me try it out on my own even if I get frustrated. Soothe me with your empathy and understanding for my growing will. I want to be big and capable like you!"

Example of a core belief pattern around autonomy:

- Limiting: "I'm a loner and it's wrong. I don't accept help."
- Expansive: "I need my space, and that's okay."

Beauty: "I create my view of the world by what I see around me. I love to experience beautiful things with all of my senses. And I love to know that I am intrinsically beautiful on the inside. Give me authentic appreciation, not excess praise. Appreciate the beauty of my mind, my spirit, my heart, not just my physical appearance."

Example of a core belief pattern around beauty:

- Limiting: "I am ugly. I have to look a certain way to be worthy of love."
- Expansive: "I am beautiful inside of me."

Creative Expression: "My creations may not be the way that you would create. Yet, I need for you to recognize and acknowledge my unique creativity, even if that's when I'm just a baby and I express through gurgles and giggles."

Example of a core belief pattern around creative expression:

- Limiting: "I can't create anything."
- Enhancing: "I am open and creative."

Fun and Play: "This is how I express myself. I live in a world of fun and play. Sometimes I think it's my job as a kid to remind the adults of how to do this! Encourage me to play and join me here, it's one of the best ways for us to connect. Play is a child's 'work'."

Example of a core belief pattern around creative expression:

- Limiting: "My purpose doesn't matter."
- Enhancing: "My instincts make sense. What I have to offer to the world matters."

Harmony: "My environment is everything. The energy that you create in the home, including how you express your emotions and your anger, deeply affects me. Create a peaceful and harmonious environment for us in the home. That way I feel safe, loved, and peaceful inside."

Example of a core belief pattern around harmony:

- Limiting: "Chaos is everywhere."
- Enhancing: "I am peaceful."

Rhythm: "I appreciate having a rhythm to my day. I like to know when things are coming, this makes me feel safe."

Example of a core belief pattern around rhythm:

- Limiting: "My life is out of control."
- Enhancing: "I trust in the natural order of the day."

Respect: "I'm learning about myself, what it means to be human and this incredible world around me. Show me respect for my entire being: for my body, my mind and my soul. I need respect and I learn respect from how you respect me."

Example of a core belief pattern around respect:

- Limiting: "I'm stupid."
- Enhancing: "I respect myself."

Rest: "I need rest because I am growing rapidly. Be aware of when I may need rest and plan ahead. I need you to support me by allowing unplanned spaces in my day to just rest. Resting my body and mind allows me the space to rejuvenate and regulate emotions before they get heated."

Example of a core belief pattern around rest:

- Limiting: "I am always overwhelmed."
- Enhancing: "I rest when I need it."

Safety and Protection: "Safety is very important for me. I need to feel safe. I need for you to watch out for me and guide me to what's safe and what is not safe. Remember, I'm young and I don't have the life experience that you do!"

Example of a core belief pattern around safety:

- Limiting: "I am not safe."
- Enhancing: "I am safe and protected."

Trust: "I need your trust in me and my abilities. As I grow, I need to feel that you trust who I am as a person and my choices."

Example of a core belief pattern around trust:

- Limiting: "Nobody trusts me. I don't trust myself."
- Enhancing: "I am trustworthy."



Universal Human Needs and Values

Play Community / Belonging	Understanding Autonomy / Authenticity	Sustenance / Health Meaning / Contribution
Adventure Cooperation Fun Fellowship Humor Generosity Joy Inclusion Laughter Interdependence Relaxation Harmony, Peace Spontaneity Solidary Aliveness Hospitality/Welcoming	Empathy Choice Awareness Privacy Acceptance Power Acknowledgement Honesty Communication Congruence Consideration Consistency Hear, be heard Continuity Know/Be known Dignity Respect, equality Freedom See/Be seen Integrity Sensitivity Empowerment	Abundance Appreciation/Gratitude Exercise Achievement/Productivity Food/Nutrition Celebration/Mourning Rest, sleep Effectiveness/Feedback Shelter Growth/Learning Sustainability Participation Support/Help Purpose Value
Safety / Security	Rest	Love / Caring
Comfort Confidence Familiarity Rhythm Structure Protection Trust/Faith	Balance Ease Relaxation Rejuvenated Simplicity Space/Tranquility Wholeness Wonder	Affection/Warmth Closeness/Touch Companionship Compassion, Kindness Intimacy Mattering/Importance Respect/Honoring

Understanding Faux Feelings

Faux feelings are perceptions rather than feelings based in emotion (Rosenberg, 2015, 41). They imply that someone is doing something to you and often connote wrongness or blame. When they are used, they are often preceded by the phrase "I feel...." The table below lists examples of these faux feelings in the left-hand column. The middle column suggests the true feelings the speaker may be experiencing when using this faux-feeling word. The third column suggests the unmet needs of the speaker.

Emotional Awareness: I feel sad and lonely. I am in need of comfort, care, and warmth.

This is NOT emotional awareness:

1. I feel *ignored by you*.
2. I feel *unwanted by you*.
3. I feel *disrespected by my child*.
4. I feel *taken for granted*.
5. I feel *rejected by you*.
6. I feel *manipulated by my kids*.

Faux feelings	Feelings	Needs
Abandoned	Terrified, Hurt, Bewildered, Sad, Frightened, Lonely	Nurturing, Connection, Belonging, Support, Caring
Abused	Angry, Frustrated, Frightened	Caring, Nurturing, Support, Well-being
(Not) accepted	Upset, Scared, Lonely	Inclusion, Connection, Community, Belonging
Attacked	Scared, Angry	Safety
Belittled	Angry, Frustrated, Tense, Distressed	Respect, Autonomy, To Be Seen, Acknowledgment
Betrayed	Angry, Hurt, Disappointed, Enraged	Trust, Dependability, Honesty, Honor
Blamed	Angry, Scared, Confused, Antagonistic, Hostile	Accountability, Causality, Fairness, Justice
Bullied	Angry, Scared, Pressured	Autonomy, Choice, Safety, Consideration
Cheated	Resentful, Hurt, Angry	Honesty, Fairness, Justice, Trust, Reliability
Coerced	Angry, Frustrated, Frightened, Thwarted, Scared	Choice, Autonomy, Freedom, Act Freely

Complete list can be found at <https://makinglifemorewonderful.com.au/faux-feelings/>

Emotion Coaching Ourselves & Our Children

Emotion coaching helps us as parents understand the best way to respond to our children's big feelings and big expressions. We model emotional intelligence to our children by showing them how we, as adults, navigate through our own emotional waters in a healthy way. Let's explore how you can best serve your child, step by step, during big feelings.

SOOTHE: The 6 Phases of Emotion Coaching

Based on the work of Daniel Siegel and Tina Payne Bryson, we understand that when our child is swept away by big emotions, their brain is doing its job! Our children live in the emotional center of their brain for the first decade (or more!) of their lives. It is our job to strengthen their emotional regulation center in their brain by responding appropriately to their emotional meltdowns. Soothing our children THROUGH *not* OUT of their emotions builds our children's brains and bodies into emotionally mature and resilient adults.

- **S:** Sink into your ANCHOR
- **O:** Open your HARBOR
- **O:** Offer empathy & validation
- **T:** Tools for sensory calming
- **H:** Hear your child
- **E:** Explore options for the future

Sink Into Your ANCHOR

What our children need from us in their most challenging moments, is for us to be ANCHORED in our internal safety. We are anchored into expansive beliefs that: *"This feeling is normal," "I am safe in this moment,"* and we can exercise our own sensory calming tools so we can regulate our child's brain and body, and soothe them through their emotional process and into internal emotional safety.

Open Your HARBOR

Once we are rooted in presence and an expansive belief system, we hold space for our child's emotional process without judgment.



If they are so upset that their nervous system is in fight or flight, thus causing aggression to occur, you can block your body from being hit, and or you can move the child into a “yes” space where they can express their emotions through their body without anyone or anything becoming hurt or damaged.

We can open our physical arms, our heart of unconditional love, and our attachment to them as their “safe space.” This is where radical de-conditioning comes in! Most likely, you’ve been taught that big emotions from kids are to be stopped and controlled. The evidence shows us that this is the furthest thing from the truth, and counteracts our children’s emotional regulation development.

We must create a space of non-judgment for them. If it takes them 45 minutes to move through their emotions, then it takes 45 minutes. No judgment. No wrong. No stories projected onto them. Remember to ANCHOR when you find yourself running out of “holding space steam,” and ask a loved one to tag team with you in space holding if necessary (and if available).

Understand that their “emotional backpack” needs unloading and they must get this pent up energy out of their system! Kids don’t stuff their feelings down like adults do. They have no choice developmentally but to FEEL. We hold the space for them to do just that, however it looks, however long it takes. No fixing, no rushing, no rescuing. This is the “feel it to heal it” portion of Daniel Siegel’s work.

Offer Empathy And Validation

Our communication is short and sweet. We are not trying to logic our child out of their feelings. We ARE attempting to place a name for the feelings to move the child through the emotion and into their prefrontal cortex.

This is the “name it to frame it” portion of Daniel Siegel’s work. We can put a story to the child’s experience, validating and giving form to the whirlwind of emotion inside their body. Sometimes a child is not ready to hear words, and your attempt to validate their experience and make empathy guesses only escalates their emotions and raises their thermometer. That is totally okay! We are meeting our child in their current state.

If you notice your validation and empathy is making things “worse” for the child, focus on non verbal empathy (facial expression matching theirs, low slow sounds of compassion, proximity, visualization of your child moving through the emotion and finding safety once again).



An example could sound something like: *"Mmmmm, sweetheart. Yeah.....mm, it's tricky, isn't it? You were really hoping for a turn on the bike before we needed to leave. I feel how upsetting this is for you. Your feelings are safe with me. Take your time".*

Instead of: *"It's okay hun! You'll get a turn next time! Aw, don't cry, you're okay. You'll get a turn first next time, ok?"*

This first example shows the child that their parent is capable and cares enough to center the child's emotional experience and shows them: what you feel makes sense. Here's why, the second example shows us that the parent is not capable or willing to support a child through an emotion, but rather wants to bring them out of it quickly. This teaches the child that emotions are a problem in need of a solution.

Tools For Sensory Calming

If your child is ready and willing to receive more actionable support, beyond your arms and the comfort of attachment and proximity, you can introduce an external sensory calming tool. Below are a few calming tools discussed in Week 5 that you can offer to your child once they are done expressing their emotion, and ready to begin the process of returning to calm.

Similar to validation and empathy, if you introduce a sensory calming tool that escalates your child, let it go, and return to your ANCHOR and hold space for your child's process without judgment, need to fix, or need to rush the process.

- Encourage the child to breathe into their belly. They can pretend to blow a balloon as big as the room, or to blow out 100 pretend candles! We want them to take in a deep inhale and an intentional, long exhale.
- Offer the child some ice to chew on. Once the bulk of the emotion has been moved through their body, some cold ice to munch can activate their parasympathetic branch of the nervous system, and their prefrontal cortex back "online."
- Invite the child to do some chanting or singing with you.
- Invite the child to go outside and be grounded by nature.
- Whisper love notes into your child's ear.
- Invite the child onto the swing.
- Offer a piggy back ride around the house. Ramp up the speed and sillies to get the child giggling.
- Invite the child to go for a couple laps around the yard.
- Put on some music or cuddle up with a story.

- Full-body twisting, left and right (engages opposite hemispheres of the brain).
- Any reclining movement that opens up the chest and belly (crab walk, backbend).
- Giant hugs (Hug yourself! Hug me! Hug a pillow!).
- See which of your hands can squeeze the other hand longer; squeeze, squeeze, squeeze (stop if it hurts).
- Ask the child if they'd like to lay their head down in your lap and get their scalp massaged.

Hear Your Child

When the child is calm, we can encourage your child's brain and emotional intelligence development by inviting them into reflection. You can ask the child to tell a story, in their own words, about what happened that created such big feelings. If they can't express in words what happened, you could tell the story, or you could draw, write, or paint the story of what happened collaboratively with your child.

We may think that going over the story again and again would only "stir the pot" and make things more difficult for the child, but the opposite can be true. As Daniel Siegel says, "It's not about what happened to you, it's about how you make sense of it." This is an opportunity to create a coherent narrative with our child so they can make sense of their experience.

- *"Do you wanna talk about what happened?"*
- *"Can you tell me the story of what made you so upset?"*
- *"Is it okay if I tell the story of what happened, and you can help me?"*

Explore Options for the Future

Support your child to make a game plan for next time. If the upset could have been preventable, what steps could be taken for the next time? What ideas does your child have to solve the problem at hand? What action steps, if any, can be taken?

- *"So, I noticed that you had very big feelings that came to visit you after your train track got messed up. I also notice that your train track is on an uneven floor. I wonder, could we put the train track somewhere more stable? What do you think?"*
- *"You were feeling angry when mama didn't cook what you wanted for dinner, huh? I wonder how we could be on the same team for dinner tomorrow? Maybe we could make a menu together so you know what to expect?"*



Summary

Takeaways:

- **Emotional intelligence** is the ability to monitor one's own and others' emotions and feelings, along with the capability to use feelings to guide one's thinking and actions.
- **Using emotional intelligence in parenting** means tuning into our own feelings, needs, and beliefs as we support our children to do the same.
- **Empathy is a skill** we can develop in ourselves and teach to our children, and it supports the healthy development of our children's brains.
- **We use our bodies to embrace and practice self-empathy:**
 - F: focus on the physical sensation
 - E: embrace this moment as a temporary messenger, teaching us something
 - E: expand into the left brain with 3 feeling words
 - L: label the underlying need(s)
- **Children (like adults) have core human needs**, and their behavior is a response to whether those needs are met AND their beliefs around those needs.
- **You can become an emotion coach for your child:**
 - S: sink into your ANCHOR
 - O: open your HARBOR
 - O: offer empathy and validation
 - T: tools for sensory calming
 - H: hear your child
 - E: explore options for the future

Invitation to Practice

- **Check-in with your body** and how you are *feeling* in the moment. (p. 18-19)
- **Reflect on a snap reaction** and rewrite a response rooted in empathy for yourself. (p. 17)
- **Reflect on a time** when you perceived your child's needs were met, when they felt strong emotions. Explore the possible limiting beliefs your child has around that need. (p. 22-25)
- **Review faux feelings** to hone your skill of recognizing perceptions versus feelings. (p. 27)
- **Practice identifying your internalized beliefs** by prefacing your reactive thoughts with "I tell myself a story that ____" and notice how you can consciously shift your perspective.



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